
The Influence of Social Alliances with Sports Teams on Intentions to Purchase Corporate Sponsors' Products

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Sponsorship has become an increasingly popular form of marketing communications, yet little is known about what might influence consumers' intentions to purchase a sponsor's products. The focus here is on how the social alliances existing between fans and a preferred sports team influence purchase intentions. Data from a convenience sample of 678 adults attending a college football game suggest that favorable purchase intentions are more likely to occur (1) as identification with the team increases and (2) when such intentions are perceived as a group norm. Moreover, an ordinal interaction indicates that team identification has a greater effect on intentions at lower levels of group norms than at higher levels. Implications for practice are discussed.

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What sponsors need now are not more signs, but opportunities to *connect* with consumers . . . Value today rests exclusively with properties that deliver *loyal audiences and activation vehicles* that allow sponsors to create brand preference (emphasis in the original; Ukman 1998, p. 2).

Sponsorship may be defined as "an investment, in cash or in kind, in an activity, in return for access to the exploitable commercial potential associated with that activity" (Meenaghan 1991, p. 36). According to industry newsletter *IEG Sponsorship Report* (1999c), North American corporations invested approximately \$7.6 billion on sponsorships in 1999 with the majority being spent on sports properties (67%). These figures represent just the fees paid for sponsorship rights by companies and do not include the additional expenditures required for leveraging the association through advertising, tie-in promotions and client entertainment.

Like other forms of marketing communication, marketers use sponsorship to achieve two main objectives (Gwinner 1997). First, sponsorship is used to increase brand awareness by exposing the brand to as many potential consumers as possible through the use of on-site signage, identification on printed promotional materials, and media coverage. Second, marketers seek to establish, enhance or change a brand image by linking their brands to a favorite cause, event or sports team (i.e., sponsee or property). In a process similar to celebrity endorsement (McCracken 1989; see McDaniel 1999), Keller (1993) has noted that some of the cognitive associations or personal meanings people hold toward the property (e.g., fun, youthful, exciting, excellence) may become linked in memory to the brand. After identifying the nature of these secondary associations, they may be leveraged in other promotional activities by advertisers. In the case of sports sponsorship, a particularly relevant secondary association is the social alliance existing between a fan and the property.

The term social alliance is conceptualized here using a social identity framework (Hogg and Abrams 1988; Tajfel 1982). This perspective suggests that discrete social categories such as organizational memberships, age cohorts and religious groups often become incorporated inextricably with a person's sense of self. Such a person is likely to say that the group is "a part

of me." For those most highly identified, self-categorization involves the private acceptance of the group's norms, values and goals which, in turn, leads to prototypical behavior. In effect, highly identified individuals are both more likely to be influenced by the perceived expectations of other group members and to act in ways that reinforce their membership to the group. Consequently, the current study investigates how group norms and identification with a sponsee influence consumers' intentions to purchase products from a corporate sponsor.

Background

In a recent review, Cornwell and Maignan (1998) argued that the main shortcoming of the empirical research on sponsorship is that it has generally been descriptive in nature and has ignored the underlying theories and conceptual foundations that explain how sponsorship operates. In particular, they suggested that a better understanding of consumers' levels of attachment to a sponsee and its effect on their intentions toward buying sponsors' products represents a promising area for future research. Similarly, Meenaghan (1999) urged researchers to move beyond studying sponsorship effects in terms of simple awareness by considering how the association between a sponsor and property affects the consumer. Although previous work has addressed the "rub off" effect that occurs from a property to a sponsor in general terms (Javalgi et al. 1994; Stipp and Schiavone 1996), none has explicitly considered the direct and indirect effects of consumers' affiliation with the property on consumers' intentions to purchase sponsors' products.

A person's sense of connectedness to a cause, event, or sports team is reminiscent of Belk's (1988) notion of an extended self. This perspective suggests that people form emotional attachments to physical possessions, places, people and groups. Belk argued that the self consists of a hierarchical ordering of multiple selves that range from the idiosyncratic and individual self to the collective self. Just as possessions may be used to distinguish a person from others at the individual level, so too may possessions be used to signal group identity and express belonging to a group. Possessions in this case need not be individually owned products. They can also include shared consumption objects such as political leaders, media stars, public monuments and sports teams.

The topic of group extended self has been described elsewhere in terms of social identity. A group of people sharing the same social identity represent a "psychological group" (Turner 1984, p. 530). Members of a

psychological group do not necessarily have to interact with or even like others in the group. Rather, it is the person's own perception of being, say, a loyal citizen or sports fan that serves as the basis for incorporating that status into his or her social identity. An awareness that at least a part of one's extended self is included in a psychological group may explain acts of patriotism and volunteerism. Nonreciprocal acts such as these are seen as benefitting the broader communities embodied within the extended self (Belk 1988). Thus, acting in ways that promote the group's best interests is based on one's social identity rather than personal identity. It is therefore not surprising that research has found that charitable giving to a particular group is positively related to identification with that group (Bhattacharya, Rao and Glynn 1995; Mael and Ashforth 1992).

Social identification is thought to occur in three stages (Hogg and Abrams 1988). First, social categorization occurs wherein both the individual and others are perceived, defined or recognized as members of a distinct social group. Next, the common or representative attributes, behaviors and norms that define and differentiate groups from one another are learned. The final stage, self-stereotyping, involves assigning the perceived norms of the group to the self. For example, baseball fans quickly learn that behaviors such as cheering for the home team and wearing clothes emblazoned with the team's logo show support for a favorite team. Fans understand that the more involved they are in these types of activities, the more they are seen as being committed to the team. Group membership also requires limitations on behaviors in the sense that fans know not to cheer for the opposing team and boo the home team's players.

Central to the idea of social identity is that groups adopt informal rules or group norms in order to regulate and judge members' behavior. Group norms specify what members are expected to do in a given situation (see Homans 1950) and are positively related to actions that express the values of the group and clarify its distinctiveness (Feldman 1984). Although compliance is not expected to ever be universal, there is a clear normative tendency toward actions that exemplify and reinforce group norms (e.g., Grube, Morgan and McGree 1986; Terry and Hogg 1996; White, Terry and Hogg 1994). It is reasonable to expect, therefore, that an intention to purchase products from a company that provides financial support to the object of a psychological group's affection is likely to be greater when such an intention is viewed as an informal norm that is supported by members of the group. Therefore, the first hypothesis predicts a

positive relationship between the perceived norms of other members of a psychological group and intentions to purchase products from a corporate sponsor.

Team Identification and Purchase Intentions Toward Corporate Sponsors

The social identity of interest in the current study is an individual's level of psychological attachment to or concern about a sports team (see Wann and Branscombe 1995). In a discussion of the solidarity and self-definition among British soccer fans, Hogg and Abrams (1988) argued that "support for the home team is more than an act, it is part of identification with that team and/or what it represents" (p. 128). In fact, Hirt et al. (1992) provided empirical support indicating that highly identified sports fans view team success and failure as personal success and failure. Highly identified individuals (i.e., fans) derive significant ego enhancement from their affiliation with a favorite sports team (see Cialdini et al. 1976) which leads to a number of interesting consequences. Compared to those low in identification, highly identified individuals exhibit greater physiological arousal while watching a contest featuring their favorite team (Branscombe and Wann 1992a); are more likely to show ingroup favoritism toward other fans of their favorite team (Wann and Branscombe 1995) and to derogate spectators of an opposing team (Branscombe and Wann 1994); exhibit biased attributional processing favoring their team following a game (Lau and Russell 1980; Wann and Dolan 1994); are more inclined to bask in the reflected glory of their team's success and less likely to distance themselves from the team following a loss (Wann and Branscombe 1990); have more intense affective reactions to game outcomes (Madrigal 1995; Wann et al. 1994) and have been found to exhibit better psychological adjustment (i.e., higher self-esteem, less depression) and greater life satisfaction (Branscombe and Wann 1991). Moreover, team identification has been shown to predict a number of behaviors including game attendance (Fisher and Wakefield 1998; Schurr et al. 1988), the amount of money spent on team licensed merchandise (Fisher and Wakefield 1998; Wann and Branscombe 1993), and spectator aggression following a game (Branscombe and Wann 1992b; Simons and Taylor 1992).

The current study argues that not only will those with higher levels of attachment be more likely to support the source of that identification (i.e., the property) directly, they will also be more willing to offer indirect support. Specifically, as the affiliation with a favored property increases among those who recog-

nize that a company is lending financial support to that property, so too will their willingness be to purchase that company's products. Pracejus (1998) referred to this conceptually as reciprocation. Those fans with the highest levels of identification with a sponsee will actually seek out corporate sponsors and reward them with their patronage. Anecdotal evidence supports this claim. Results from a national probability sample of more than 1000 NASCAR fans indicated that nearly three-fourths (71%) of the respondents said that they "almost always" or "frequently" chose brands of NASCAR sponsors over competitors simply because of the sponsorship. Moreover, 42% said that they switched brands after a manufacturer became a sponsor (IEG Sponsorship Report 1994). Thus, I hypothesize that after accounting for group norms, team identification will be positively related to intentions to purchase products from a corporate sponsor.

The Interactive Effects of Social Identity and Group Norms on Behavioral Intentions

The extent to which group norms influence intentions is likely to vary depending upon an individual's identification with a particular group. Some people may simply comply with a group's norms out of a need for social approval and acceptance or to avoid being chastised by other group members. These individuals publicly comply but do not privately comply (Kiesler and Kiesler 1969) or internalize (Kelman 1961) the group's values, beliefs and behaviors. Conformity as private acceptance may be explained by referent informational influence which suggests that individuals tend to act in ways that conform to their own cognitive representations of the appropriate ingroup norm (Hogg and Abrams 1988). In the domain of spectator sports, research by Kahle, Kambara and Rose (1996) found that while public compliance was related to the sense of camaraderie felt by fans attending a sporting event, internalization had a direct effect on attendance behavior.

Recently, Terry and Hogg (1996) examined how social identity and group norms interact to influence behavioral intentions. In two separate studies, they provided empirical evidence of a disordinal interaction such that group norms had an effect on intentions to engage in health-related behaviors only among those most highly identified with the group and not for low identifiers. Specifically, high identifiers who also perceived higher levels of normative pressure from other group members were most likely to form favorable intentions toward the behaviors. No differ-

ences in group norms were found for low identifiers. Terry and Hogg argued that given a context in which social identification is made salient that highly identified people not only enact a norm because others are watching, they also privately enact a group norm that prescribes how group members should act in that situation. Consistent with social identity theory, the perceived expectations of other group members mattered only to those who were most highly identified with the group. Accordingly, a disordinal interaction is expected in the current study such that the effect of group norms on intentions to purchase a sponsor's products is expected to be greater for people more highly identified with the sports team than for those with lower levels of team identification.

Method

General Procedure and Sample

Data were collected from individuals attending one of two home football games of a NCAA Division I-A university located in the Pacific Northwest in the fall of 1998. Of the 725 questionnaires distributed, complete data were obtained from 678. None of the respondents were students currently enrolled at the university. The majority of individuals comprising the sample were current season-ticket holders (65.8%) and male (62.5%). The mean age of respondents was approximately 43 years and six months ($SD=13.7$).

Individuals included as respondents in the study were initially contacted either at pre-game tailgate parties or as they entered the stadium. Data were collected by students who had upper-division or graduate-level status. The surveyors approached potential respondents and asked them for their cooperation in completing a questionnaire related to the athletic department (no mention was made of sponsorship). In order to reduce the potential influence of others attending the game with the respondent, those agreeing to participate were asked to step away from the group and instructed to complete the survey quietly. Respondents were not allowed to show or tell others in their party about the questions on the survey instrument during data collection. No more than one person per group was invited to complete the questionnaire. The questionnaires were completed in the presence of the surveyors.

Measures

Rather than asking people to base their comments on an actual sponsor of the football team, respon-

dents were simply asked about a company that sponsors the team. The use of a generic or hypothetical company was thought more appropriate in this context given that people were likely to already have opinions about real companies. Such opinions might bias the effects considered in this study (see Keller 1993).

Group norms. Two questions similar to those used by Terry and Hogg (1996) were included to assess group norms. Respondents were first asked to indicate their feelings along three semantic differential scales (admirable-silly, smart-dumb; makes sense-does not make sense; each reverse coded) in response to the following stem: "Most other fans of this team whose opinion I value would probably think my decision to buy products or services from a company because it sponsors the (university's team name) to (be)." The second question asked respondents, "On the whole, would you say most other fans of this team who are important to you would approve or disapprove of your decision to buy a sponsor's products?" (approve-disapprove, reverse coded). The four scales were summed to create the group norms construct. All semantic differential scales were scored on a 7-point scale.

Intentions. Next, respondents were told to assume that they were aware of a company's sponsorship of the football team and asked about their intentions toward buying that company's products or services. The intentions construct consisted of three 7-point semantic differential scales: extremely likely-extremely unlikely (reverse coded); not probable-probable; certain chance-no chance (reverse coded).

Team Identification. Five items from a seven-item Sports Spectator Identification Scale (SSIS) developed by Wann and Branscombe (1993) were used in this study. The two scale items not included in this study pertained to media usage and were not deemed appropriate in this context given that the survey was administered on site. The SSIS has been used extensively in research on sports fans and has been shown to be a reliable and valid measure of team identification. Using 5-point Likert scales, the items included assessed each respondent's perceptions of the importance of being a fan of the (name of university) football team (not very important-very important); the importance of the football team winning (not very important-very important); the extent to which the spectator sees him or herself as a fan of the (name of university) football team (not at all a fan-very strong fan); the degree to which friends believe the individual to be a fan of the (name of university) football team (not at all a fan-very strong fan); and how often the individual displays or wears items identifying (name of university) teams (never-very often).

Table 1
Descriptive Statistics and Construct Correlations (N=678)

<i>Measure</i>	<i>Mean</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>Range</i>	<i>ID</i>	<i>NORM</i>	<i>INT</i>
ID	20.31	4.04	5-25	.88		
NORM	19.91	4.84	4-28	.33	.86	
INT	15.42	3.53	3-21	.35	.64	.81

Notes: ID=team identification in its original metric, NORM=group norms, INT=behavioral intentions. Composite reliabilities given in the diagonal.

Results

Preliminary Analysis

Prior to the hierarchical analysis, individual items were submitted to confirmatory factor analysis in order to establish the reliability and discriminant validity of the constructs. A covariance matrix generated using PRELIS was used as input for the estimation of parameter coefficients and goodness-of-fit measures by the LISREL 8 program. The resulting model resulted in an acceptable fit, $\chi^2_{(51)}=136.12$, $p<.001$, AGFI=.95, RMSEA=.050. Composite reliabilities on each of the constructs ranged from .81 to .86 with a mean of .85 (see Table 1 for each measure's reliability coefficient). The average variance extracted for the constructs exceeded the minimum cutoff of .50 recommended by Fornell and Larcker (1981). The mean AVE was .68, suggesting that the constructs explained approximately 68% of the variance in the measured items. Evidence of discriminant validity was established in two ways (Anderson and Gerbing 1988). First, significant differences were found when one-at-a-time comparisons were made between the CFA model and alternate models where each construct correlation in the phi matrix was alternately held to 1. Second, the 95% confidence interval (i.e., plus or minus two standard errors) surrounding each construct correlation did not include the value of 1. In sum, the CFA revealed that the measures were reliable and discriminant.

Not surprisingly, given the self-selective nature of people attending a sporting event to watch a favorite team, each of the items comprising the team identification scale was highly skewed. Furthermore, although the summed group norms and intentions measures were normally distributed, the summed team identification scale was also skewed. These findings suggest that respondents tended to be moderately to highly identified with the team. Accordingly, a log transformation was applied to the summed team identification scale used in the hierarchical analysis. The resulting variable was normally distributed. Table 1

presents descriptive statistics and the correlations among the summed constructs prior to transformation.

Initial analyses indicated that control of the background variables of sex, age, season ticket status and game attended did not change the overall model. Four separate hierarchical regressions were conducted in which intentions were regressed on a background variable and its interaction with the predictors (group norms and team identification) after controlling for the predictors. The analyses revealed no significant main effects or interaction effects for the background variables. Consequently, the background variables were not considered in the main model.

Main Analysis

Hierarchical regression was performed in order to examine the additive and interaction effects of the predictors on intentions to purchase products from a corporate sponsor of the university's football team. Because interaction terms in regression models are multiplicative, all predictor variables were mean centered prior to computing the interaction terms in order to reduce the possibility of multicollinearity. Researchers have recently suggested that another routine precaution against the effects of multicollinearity when testing interaction terms is to include the predictor variables' squared terms as covariates (Cortina 1993; Lubinski and Humphreys 1990). The inclusion of squared terms reduces the possibility that a significant interaction may be due to nonlinear multiplicative effects. For the most part, research examining moderator effects using hierarchical regression have neglected possible nonlinear trends. Not considering these effects may result in misleading findings. Accordingly, the curvilinear effects of group norms and team identification were considered in the tests of multiplicative effects.

Additive effects. Testing the effects of higher order terms in hierarchical regression should proceed only after first testing for main effects. Given that team identification was expected to moderate the effect of group norms on intentions, the first variable entered

Table 2
Hierarchical Regression Predicting Purchase Intentions (N=678)

Step	Predictor	R	R ² _{adj}	ΔR ²	F _{cha}	df	β
1		.64	.41	—	479.15 ^c	1, 676	
	NORM						.61 ^c
2		.66	.44	.02	28.37 ^c	1, 675	
	ID						.15 ^c
3		.66	.44	.00	5.25 ^a	1, 674	
	NORM SQ						.09 ^b
4		.67	.45	.01	7.40 ^b	1, 673	
	ID X NORM						-.08 ^b

Notes: ID=square root transformation of team identification, NORM=group norms, NORM SQ=squared term for group norms. Beta coefficients estimated after all variables entered in the equation. a<.05; b<.01; c<.001

into the equation was group norms. The second entry was the centered log transformation of team identification, henceforth referred to simply as team identification. As shown in Table 2, group norms explained a substantial proportion of variance in intentions to purchase products or services from a corporate sponsor. As suggested in the first hypothesis, respondents were more likely to have favorable intentions toward purchasing a product from a corporate sponsor if they believed that this was in line with the norms of other fans. After controlling for group norms, the addition of team identification explained a significant increment of variance. Thus, consistent with the second hypothesis, higher levels of team identification were significantly related to more favorable purchase intentions.

Higher order effects. A process described by Aiken and West (1991) for including higher order effects into hierarchical regression models was followed to investigate the incremental contribution made by the squared terms of group norms and team identification as well as the two-way interaction. Aiken and West suggested that a global test be conducted first in which all higher-order effects are included in the model. After eliminating those higher order terms that were found not to be significant at the global level, a step-down hierarchical procedure was conducted in which each significant higher order term was entered individually after taking into account the effects of all other significant terms. By so doing, the incremental contribution of each higher order term above and beyond the other variables included in the model is explicitly considered.

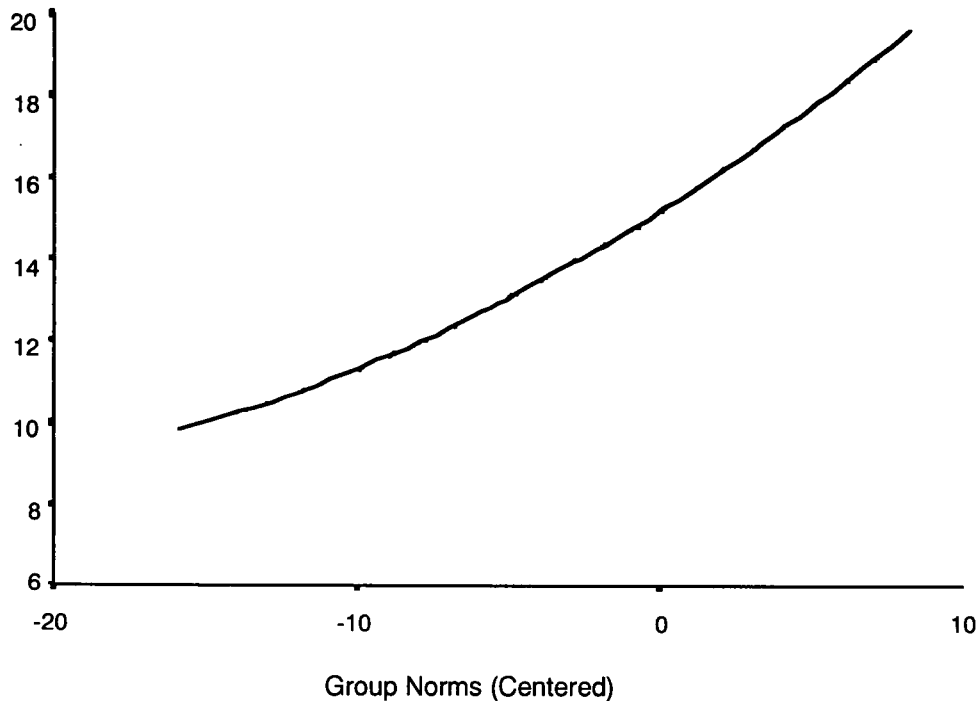
An examination of the global model that included lower order terms, their squared coefficients, and the group norms × team identification interaction revealed that the squared term for team identification was not significant. Accordingly, it was eliminated

from the model. Next, a separate analysis was conducted in which the highest order term (i.e., the two-way interaction) was the final entry into the model. The inclusion of this term was significant, $F_{cha}(1, 673)=7.20, p<.01$. Next, a regression was run in which the squared term for group norms was entered as the final variable in the model after accounting for main effects and the two-way interaction term. Again, this term was significant, $F_{cha}(1, 673)=9.51, p<.01$. In summary, although accounting for only a modest amount of incremental variance, the individual contribution of the squared group norms and two-way interaction terms were each significant.

The results of the model with the highest order term entered last is shown in Table 2. The final model explained 45% of the variance in respondents' intentions to purchase products or services from a corporate sponsor. With all of the predictors in the regression equation, the largest contributor to purchase intentions was group norms, followed by team identification. In addition to the linear contribution of group norms, an unexpected positive curvilinear effect of norms on intentions was also found. As shown in Figure 1, lower levels of group norms were more favorably related to purchase intentions than would be expected based strictly on the variable's linear contribution. Predicted scores on the intentions scale under curvilinear and linear conditions were comparable as group norms increased.

Figure 2 graphically displays the two-way interaction of team identification and group norms using a procedure described by Aiken and West (1991). The procedure involves calculating simple regression lines at exemplar high and low values corresponding with one standard deviation above and below the mean of the moderator. Aiken and West suggest that significant interactions be probed from multiple perspec-

Figure 1
Curvilinear Effect of Group Norms on Purchase Intentions



tives because each may provide "potentially informative and complementary two-dimensional representations of what is in reality a three-dimensional regression surface" (p. 23). Thus, the left side of Figure 2 (a) displays the regression of intentions on group at different levels of team identification. The upper line is the slope at higher levels of identification, whereas the lower line reflects lower team identification. Given the nature of the sample, the lower line might more appropriately be described as reflecting moderate rather than low team identification. Accordingly, the upper line will be referred to as the slope at higher levels of identification and the lower line as the slope at moderate levels of team identification. Figure 2b, on the other hand, investigates the regression of intentions on team identification at different levels of group norms. The higher (lower) slope represents higher (lower) levels of group norms.

The main effects reported earlier are immediately apparent when looking at each frame in Figure 2. Specifically, the smaller disparity in the slopes in Figure 2a compared to that seen in Figure 2b indicates that the main effect of identification on intentions was less than was the effect of group norms on intentions. Moreover, in contrast to the hypothesized disordinal interaction, it is clear from Figure 2 that the nature of the interaction was ordinal. Due to the

lesser variance around the team identification mean, the interaction is not very apparent in Figure 2a. Group norms had a comparable effect on intentions at one standard deviation below ($t=14.91$, $p<.001$) and above ($t=13.24$, $p<.001$) the team identification mean. In contrast, the ordinal interaction can be seen more clearly in Figure 2b. Whereas a modest difference was found for team identification's effect on intentions at higher levels of group norms ($t=2.40$, $p>.02$), the difference was much greater at lower levels of group norms ($t=5.10$, $p<.001$). This suggests that when the opinion of other fans is held in high regard, team identification has little influence on purchase intentions. In contrast, team identification appears to be a much better predictor of intentions among those less concerned with others' expectations.

Discussion

Prior empirical research on sponsorship has tended to focus on the medium's ability to generate consumer awareness. The results of the current study suggest that this emphasis, at least among those attending a sporting event, may be somewhat incomplete. Meenaghan (1999) has argued that future research should move away from investigating mere awareness effects and instead focus on how sponsorship

Figure 2a
Group Norms by Team Identification Interaction

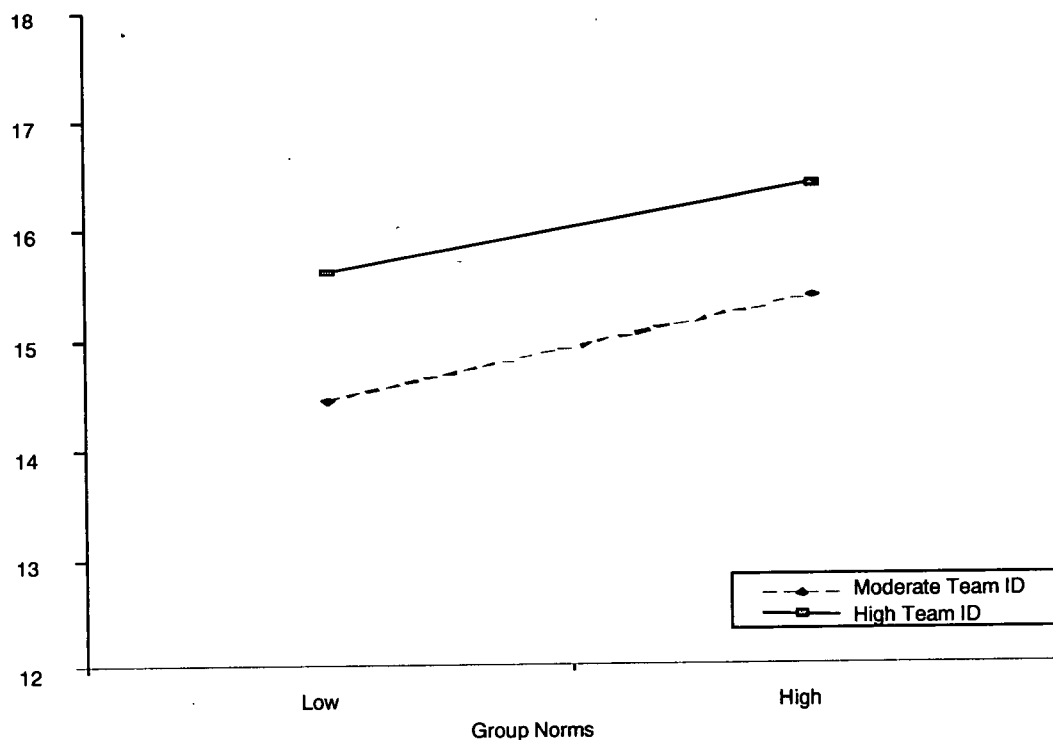
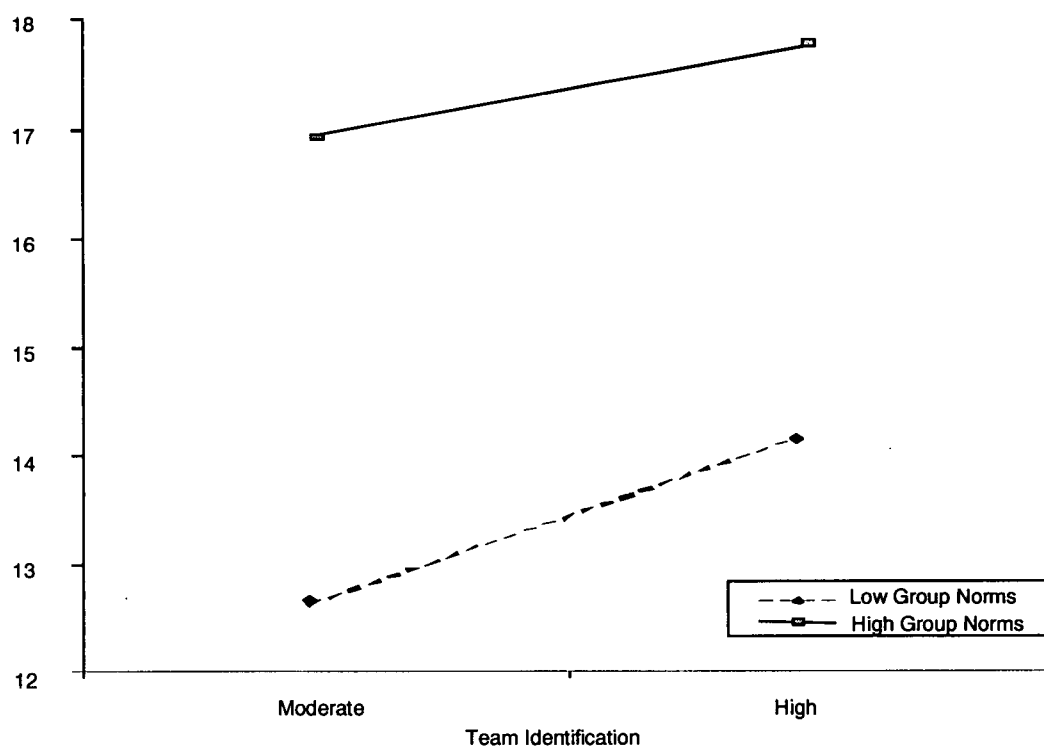


Figure 2b
Team Identification by Group Norms Interaction



linkages influence consumers. Carrying this point a little further, one might envision the parties involved in a sponsorship arrangement as comprising a triad of interconnected relations—sponsor, consumer and property. Others have discussed the influence of one element of the triad on the others in terms of balance theory (Crimmins and Horn 1996; Pracejus 1998; see Heider 1958). Whereas Meenaghan's comment points to the effect of the sponsor—property relation on consumers, the current study focused on how sports fans' social alliances with a preferred team influence their intentions to buy products from a sponsor of that team.

Recently, Oliver (1999) discussed how group identification and group norms contribute to social alliances that lead to consumer loyalty. He argued that the motivation to become loyal to a consumable object often stems from a consumer's desire to be part of the group. The object in this case is not limited merely to products and services. Rather, the object that is consumed is the camaraderie offered by the group. According to Oliver, ultimate loyalty occurs when the consumable becomes embedded in a consumer's extended self (see Belk 1988) such that it becomes "part and parcel of the consumer's self-identity and his or her social identity" (p. 40). The affiliation in this case is pursued by the consumer, persistent over time, and resistant to change. Members voluntarily choose to act in ways that exemplify the perceived will of the group in order to enjoy the psychological benefits of membership. Oliver concluded by noting that consumers want to be loyal, the groups to which they belong want them to be loyal, and as a result the two contribute to a symbiotic relationship.

The results found in this study appear to support this perspective and suggest that loyalty toward a preferred team may have beneficial consequences for corporate sponsors. Consistent with the idea of in-group favoritism, higher levels of team identification among attendees of a sporting event appear to be positively related to intentions to purchase a sponsor's products. Moreover, the findings provide evidence of the normative pressure associated with referent information influence. Favorable purchase intentions are more likely to occur when such intentions are perceived as important to other members of the group. This implies that psychological connectedness to a sports team represents an important aspect of self-identity that contributes to a group norm which, in turn, prescribes certain behavioral intentions that are considered to be supportive of the team.

Two higher order effects involving group norms were also found to be significant in this study. A cautionary note, however, is warranted here because the

combined influence of both terms in the model explains just slightly more than one percent of the variance. Thus, their contribution relative to the additive effects was quite modest. Nevertheless, the findings are interesting in the sense that they diverge from Terry and Hogg's (1996) results. A possible reason for these effects may be attributable to sample composition. The majority of respondents were season ticket holders and all had at least gone to the trouble of attending the game. As evidenced by the skewed distribution of the identification measure prior to transformation, most respondents were at least moderately identified with the team. Thus, in regard to the curvilinear effect, it is possible that even those with lower levels of group norms still include the team as part of their extended selves and are therefore more inclined to support the team by forming favorable purchase intentions. This supposition gains further credence when the two-way interaction is considered. As team identification increases at lower levels of group norms, so too do purchase intentions. Although this was also true at higher levels of group norms, the ordinal interaction suggests that identification had a greater effect when group norms were lower. In sum, at least among those attending a sporting event, team identification appears to compensate for lower levels of group norms when it comes to forming intentions to purchase products from a corporate sponsor.

Implications

The results of this study suggest two implications for practice. To begin with, the findings indicate that event attendees possessing a lower level of group norms and a moderate level of team identification are least favorably inclined to purchase a sponsor's products. In contrast, as group norms and identification increase, so do purchase intentions. This implies that properties would be well advised to create social situations in which the alliance existing between themselves and their fans might be strengthened. An excellent example of how this might be accomplished is America's Pack, a fan club created by the National Football League's Green Bay Packers in 1990. In addition to a number of exclusive benefits (e.g., quarterly newsletter, discounts on team merchandise), members of America's Pack are given opportunities to interact socially with other fans both at the game (e.g., club tailgate parties) and at more remote locations through the group's "Watch and Listen" program. "Watch and Listen" attempts to enact group norms by informing members that it is their responsibility to watch the team play regardless of where

they live. Toward that end, the program fosters a sense of community among fans by inviting them to visit any one of a number of establishments located throughout the United States that regularly feature Packer games on television. Another way of building a sense of community among supporters is by providing local chapters supporting the central organization. This is a fairly common practice for university alumni associations and athletic teams (e.g., the Cleveland Browns Backers have more than 15,000 members who are divided into 146 local chapters). Just as when fans attend a game in person, programs such as these provide a social context that increases the salience of social identification, thus enhancing the likelihood that group norms will be enacted. Sponsors might become formally involved with such programs by either hosting them or having a presence at the gatherings. Such gatherings would provide an ideal environment for on-site product demonstration and sampling.

A second implication of this study is the need for properties to provide companies with exclusive opportunities for leveraging the sponsorship in ways that tap into attendees' loyalty. Companies that do this successfully will differentiate themselves from competitors and increase the likelihood that fans will feel a sense of reciprocation (Pracejus 1998). Affinity programs offer just such an opportunity. For example, California Federal Bank offered team-themed checking accounts on site and at 16 branch offices as part of their sponsorship of the National Hockey League's San Jose Sharks. This led to over 2000 new checking accounts and more than \$4 million in deposits, a 300% return on investment (IEG Sponsorship Report 1999a, p. 1). Another example is America West Airline's sponsorship of the Phoenix Open. The company's total involvement with the Open was a \$500 investment in water coolers that provided free water to attendees at every hole. Each water cooler included signage attributing the free refreshment to America West. The company provided something important to attendees watching a golf tournament in the hot desert sun. Post-event recall of America West as an official sponsor of the Open was substantially higher than that for other sponsors who spent significantly more (IEG Sponsorship Report 1999b, p. 3).

Limitations

As implied earlier, one limitation of this study is its use of a sample drawn from a narrow range (i.e., upper end) of team identifiers. It is likely that the general population would not be as favorably inclined toward the team as the individuals sampled in this

study. However, it is also possible that the results reported here were subject to a ceiling effect and would have been more pronounced had a random sample been used. In any event, given that the unique nature of sports fanaticism makes it unlikely that a normal distribution would ever be observed on team identification among attendees of any game featuring that team, future sponsorship research would do well to consider identification with other types of sponsees.

A second limitation related to the sample is the inclusion of just attendees of the sporting event. For the most part, the people participating in this study were attending with others and in a social situation. Although this may be representative of fans attending a college football game, the situation nonetheless emphasizes a sense of community and community norms that may not be typical of non-attendees. After all, far more people watch or listen to Division I-A college football games via media than actually attend. Thus, caution is warranted when making generalizations from this study until more is known about the differences and similarities of on-site attendees and media consumers.

Third, the focus in this study was on intentions toward a generic company rather than an actual team sponsor. Although Keller (1993) warned that using real brand names is likely to introduce a number of unintended consequences that detract from the focal theoretical factors of interest in a study such as this, it might be interesting to consider how an actual company or brand's personality (see Aaker 1997) would influence the results found here. More specifically, does identification with a sponsee moderate the effect of a sponsor's corporate image on purchase intentions? For example, would highly identified individuals still look favorably on buying products from a sponsor that has a negative reputation? Or, alternatively, would companies with negative reputations have the most to gain from sponsorship? Again, more research is needed to answer these questions.

Conclusion

The results of this study suggest that an important benefit derived from sponsorship is the opportunity for a company to link itself to an object that constitutes part of a consumer's extended self. It is unlikely that consumers in general, or attendees of an event in particular, will feel any passion toward a product; they do, however, have strong feelings about the causes, events and sports teams with which they are affiliated. Companies that are able to successfully tap into a consumer's psychological connectedness to

a property align themselves to something much more meaningful to that individual than a mere product. It would appear that rather than creating mere awareness, the promise of sponsorship may lie in the opportunity to capture a consumer's "share of heart."

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